TITLE 3 THEME 1 CHILD

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SHADOWS AND SURPRISES
Finding Jesus in the Weirdest Old Testament Rules
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A Note for Parents

Have you ever read a rule in the Old Testament and thought, "Wait, what?" Maybe it was a rule about not wearing clothes made of two different fabrics. Maybe it was a rule about not eating shellfish. Maybe it was a rule about mold on a wall. Some of these rules seem so weird.

But here is the secret. God does not do random things. Every rule has a reason. Every rule has a purpose. Every rule is a clue. It is a shadow. It is a surprise. It is pointing to something. It is pointing to someone. That someone is Jesus.

This book is a 30 day adventure for you and your kids. We are going to look at some of the weirdest rules in the Old Testament. We are going to ask, "Why did God give this rule?" And we are going to discover the surprise. The surprise is always Jesus. Get ready to laugh. Get ready to learn. Get ready to find Jesus in the strangest places.

How to Use This Book

This is a 30 day journey. Each day takes about 5 to 10 minutes. Read the weird rule. Read the big surprise. Do the family activity together. Say the prayer out loud. Let your child color the picture. The goal is not perfection. The goal is connection. Have fun with it. Get messy. Ask questions. Laugh together. This is an adventure. Let us begin.

Day 01: The Rule About Two Fabrics

The Weird Rule
"Do not wear clothing woven of two kinds of material." - Leviticus 19:19

God told His people not to wear clothes made of two different fabrics. No wool and linen mixed together. No cotton and polyester. Just one fabric. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about what your shirt is made of?

The Big Surprise
"For all of you who were baptized into Christ have clothed yourselves with Christ." - Galatians 3:27

The rule about two fabrics was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. God wanted His people to be set apart. He wanted them to be pure. He wanted them to be one. Jesus makes us one. He clothes us with Himself. We do not need to mix anything with Him. He is enough.

Family Activity
Look at the tags on your clothes. Find one piece of clothing that is made of one fabric. Talk about how God wanted His people to be set apart. Talk about how Jesus sets us apart. We are clothed with Christ.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for clothing me with yourself. Thank you for making me one. Thank you for being enough. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A shirt with a big heart on it.

Day 02: The Rule About Shellfish

The Weird Rule
"But all creatures in the seas or streams that do not have fins and scales—whether among all the swarming things or among all the other living creatures in the water—you are to regard as unclean." - Leviticus 11:10

God told His people not to eat shellfish. No shrimp. No crab. No lobster. No clams. Only fish with fins and scales. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about what you eat for dinner?

The Big Surprise
"Do not call anything impure that God has made clean." - Acts 10:15

The rule about shellfish was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. God used these rules to teach His people about being set apart. But Jesus came to make all things clean. He came to remove the barrier. He came to bring everyone in. The surprise is that Jesus makes the unclean clean.

Family Activity
Draw a picture of a fish with fins and scales. Draw a picture of a shrimp or a crab. Talk about how God gave His people special rules. Talk about how Jesus makes all things clean. We do not have to worry about being clean enough. Jesus makes us clean.

Kid's Prayer

"Thank you, Jesus, for making me clean. Thank you for removing the barrier. Thank you for bringing me in. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A fish with big scales and a big smile.

Day 03: The Rule About Mold

The Weird Rule
"When anyone has a swelling or a rash or a shiny spot on their skin that may be a defiling skin disease, they must be brought to Aaron the priest or to one of his sons who is a priest." - Leviticus 13:2

God gave His people rules about mold. Rules about skin diseases. Rules about houses with mold. The priest had to inspect the mold. The priest had to decide if it was clean or unclean. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about mold?

The Big Surprise
"He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn over all creation." - Colossians 1:15

The rule about mold was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The priest inspected the mold. He decided if it was clean or unclean. Jesus is our High Priest. He inspects our hearts. He makes us clean. He removes the mold of sin. He makes us new.

Family Activity
Look around your house for something that is dirty or moldy. Talk about how the priest inspected the mold. Talk about how Jesus inspects our hearts. He makes us clean. He removes the dirt. He makes us new.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being my High Priest. Thank you for inspecting my heart. Thank you for making me clean. Thank you for removing the mold of sin. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A heart with a sparkle and a big smile.

Day 04: The Rule About Mixed Seeds

The Weird Rule
"Do not plant your field with two kinds of seed." - Leviticus 19:19

God told His people not to plant two different kinds of seeds in the same field. No wheat and barley together. No corn and beans. Just one kind of seed. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about farming?

The Big Surprise
"The kingdom of heaven is like a man who sowed good seed in his field." - Matthew 13:24

The rule about mixed seeds was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the good seed. He is the one who plants good things in our lives. He does not mix His truth with lies. He does not mix His love with hate. He is pure. He is good. He is the good seed.

Family Activity
Plant a seed in a cup. Watch it grow over the next few weeks. Talk about how Jesus is the good seed. Talk about how He plants good things in our lives. We can grow in Him.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the good seed. Thank you for planting good things in my life. Help me to grow in you. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A seed with a green sprout and a big smile.

Day 05: The Rule About Tassels

The Weird Rule
"Speak to the Israelites and say to them: 'Throughout the generations to come you are to make tassels on the corners of your garments, with a blue cord on each tassel.'" - Numbers 15:38

God told His people to put tassels on the corners of their clothes. Blue tassels. On every corner. Every day. Every where. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about tassels?

The Big Surprise
"Just then a woman who had been subject to bleeding for twelve years came up behind him and touched the edge of his cloak." - Matthew 9:20

The rule about tassels was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The tassels were a reminder. They reminded the people of God. They reminded them of His commands. The woman touched the edge of Jesus' cloak. She touched the tassel. She was healed. The surprise is that Jesus is the one who fulfills the commands. He is the one who heals.

Family Activity
Make a tassel out of yarn or string. Tie it to your child's backpack or doorknob. Talk about how the tassels reminded the people of God. Talk about how Jesus is the one who heals. We can reach out and touch Him.

Kid's Prayer

"Thank you, Jesus, for being the one I can reach out to. Thank you for healing me. Thank you for reminding me of your love. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A tassel with a blue cord and a big smile.

Day 06: The Rule About Beard Trimming

The Weird Rule
"Do not cut the hair at the sides of your head or clip off the edges of your beard." - Leviticus 19:27

God told His people not to cut the hair at the sides of their head. He told them not to clip the edges of their beard. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about haircuts?

The Big Surprise
"But the LORD said to Samuel, 'Do not consider his appearance or his height, for I have rejected him. The LORD does not look at the things people look at. People look at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart.'" - 1 Samuel 16:7

The rule about beard trimming was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The rule was about being set apart. It was about not looking like the other nations. But God does not care about the outside. He cares about the heart. Jesus is the one who looks at the heart. He sees who we really are.

Family Activity
Look in the mirror. Talk about how God cares more about our hearts than our hair. Talk about how Jesus looks at the inside. Talk about how we can have a clean heart. Jesus makes our hearts clean.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for looking at my heart. Thank you for making my heart clean. Thank you for caring about the inside. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A heart with a smiling face inside it.

Day 07: The Rule About Tattoos

The Weird Rule
"Do not cut your bodies for the dead or put tattoo marks on yourselves. I am the LORD." - Leviticus 19:28

God told His people not to cut their bodies. He told them not to get tattoos. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about tattoos?

The Big Surprise
"Do you not know that your bodies are temples of the Holy Spirit, who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own." - 1 Corinthians 6:19

The rule about tattoos was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The rule was about honoring God with your body. It was about not being like the other nations. It was about being set apart. Jesus is the one who makes our bodies holy. He is the one who makes us temples of the Holy Spirit.

Family Activity
Look at your hands. Look at your feet. Talk about how our bodies are temples of the Holy Spirit. Talk about how we can honor God with our bodies. Jesus makes us holy.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for making my body a temple. Thank you for making me holy. Help me to honor you with my body. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A body with a big heart in the middle.

Day 08: The Rule About Mixed Threads

The Weird Rule
"Do not wear clothing woven of two kinds of material." - Leviticus 19:19

God told His people not to wear clothes made of two different fabrics. No wool and linen mixed together. Just one fabric. This seems like a strange rule. We already talked about this. But there is more to it. It is about purity. It is about being set apart. It is about not mixing things that should not be mixed.

The Big Surprise
"For he is our peace, who has made the two groups one and has destroyed the barrier, the dividing wall of hostility." - Ephesians 2:14

The rule about mixed threads was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the one who makes us one. He destroys the barrier. He removes the division. He brings us together. The surprise is that Jesus takes the mixed threads and makes them one.

Family Activity
Take two pieces of different colored yarn. Tie them together. Talk about how Jesus brings different people together. He makes us one. He removes the division. He brings us together.

Kid's Prayer

"Thank you, Jesus, for making us one. Thank you for destroying the barrier. Thank you for bringing us together. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
Two hands holding each other with a big heart.

Day 09: The Rule About the Corner of the Field

The Weird Rule
"When you reap the harvest of your land, do not reap to the very edges of your field or gather the gleanings of your harvest." - Leviticus 19:9

God told His people not to harvest the edges of their fields. They were to leave some behind. They were to leave some for the poor. They were to leave some for the foreigner. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about farming?

The Big Surprise
"God presented Christ as a sacrifice of atonement, through the shedding of his blood." - Romans 3:25

The rule about the corner of the field was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The rule was about generosity. It was about leaving something for others. Jesus left everything. He gave His life. He gave His blood. He gave everything for us. The surprise is that Jesus is the one who provides.

Family Activity
Set aside some food or toys to donate to someone in need. Talk about how the people left the edges of their fields for the poor. Talk about how Jesus gave everything for us. We can be generous too.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for giving everything for me. Thank you for being generous. Help me to be generous too. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A field with a basket of food and a big smile.

Day 10: The Rule About the Poor Man's Sheep

The Weird Rule
"If anyone is found guilty of stealing an ox or a sheep and slaughters it or sells it, they must pay back five head of cattle for the ox and four sheep for the sheep." - Exodus 22:1

God gave a rule about stealing. If someone stole a sheep, they had to pay back four sheep. If someone stole an ox, they had to pay back five oxen. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about sheep and oxen?

The Big Surprise
"If the thief is caught, he must pay back fourfold." - Luke 19:8

The rule about the poor man's sheep was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The rule was about restitution. It was about making things right. Jesus is the one who makes things right. He is the one who pays back what was stolen. He is the one who restores what was lost. The surprise is that Jesus pays it back for us.

Family Activity
Play a game of "trade." Trade a toy with your child. Then give it back. Talk about how the rules were about making things right. Talk about how Jesus makes things right. He pays back what we owe. He restores what we lost.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for making things right. Thank you for paying back what I owe. Thank you for restoring what I lost. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A sheep with a big heart on it.

Day 11: The Rule About a Kid in Its Mother's Milk

The Weird Rule
"Do not cook a young goat in its mother's milk." - Exodus 23:19

God told His people not to cook a young goat in its mother's milk. This seems like a very strange rule. Why would God care about how you cook a goat?

The Big Surprise
"He himself bore our sins in his body on the cross, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; by his wounds you have been healed." - 1 Peter 2:24

The rule about the kid in its mother's milk was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The rule was about reverence for life. It was about not being cruel. Jesus is the one who gives life. He is the one who died for us. He bore our sins. He healed us. The surprise is that Jesus is the one who gives life, not death.

Family Activity
Talk about how God cares about all living things. Talk about how we should be kind to animals. Talk about how Jesus is the one who gives life. He loves all His creation.

Kid's Prayer

"Thank you, Jesus, for giving me life. Thank you for caring about all living things. Help me to be kind. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A mother goat and a baby goat with a big heart.

Day 12: The Rule About the Bird's Nest

The Weird Rule
"If you come across a bird's nest beside the road, either in a tree or on the ground, and the mother is sitting on the young or on the eggs, do not take the mother with the young." - Deuteronomy 22:6

God told His people not to take a mother bird with her eggs. They could take the eggs. They had to let the mother go. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about a bird's nest?

The Big Surprise
"How often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you were not willing." - Matthew 23:37

The rule about the bird's nest was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is like the mother bird. He wants to gather us. He wants to protect us. He wants to cover us with His wings. The surprise is that Jesus is the one who gathers us. He is the one who protects us.

Family Activity
Make a pretend bird's nest with a blanket. Sit in it with your child. Talk about how a mother bird protects her baby birds. Talk about how Jesus protects us. He gathers us under His wings.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for protecting me. Thank you for gathering me. Thank you for covering me with your wings. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A bird with her baby birds in a nest.

Day 13: The Rule About the Leper

The Weird Rule
"The person with such an infectious disease must wear torn clothes, let their hair be unkempt, cover the lower part of their face and cry out, 'Unclean! Unclean!'" - Leviticus 13:45

God told His people that lepers had to wear torn clothes. They had to let their hair be messy. They had to cover their faces. They had to cry out, "Unclean!" They had to live alone. This seems like a very strange rule. Why would God care about lepers?

The Big Surprise
"A man with leprosy came and knelt before him and said, 'Lord, if you are willing, you can make me clean.' Jesus reached out his hand and touched the man. 'I am willing,' he said. 'Be clean!'" - Matthew 8:2-3

The rule about the leper was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The leper was unclean. He was separated from the people. He was alone. Jesus reached out and touched him. Jesus made him clean. The surprise is that Jesus touches the unclean. He makes them clean. He brings them back into the community.

Family Activity
Talk about how it feels to be left out. Talk about how the leper must have felt. Talk about how Jesus touched the leper. Jesus touches us too. He makes us clean. He brings us back in.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for touching me. Thank you for making me clean. Thank you for bringing me back in. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A hand reaching out to touch a person with a big heart.

Day 14: The Rule About the Unclean Animal

The Weird Rule
"You must not eat the camel because it chews the cud but does not have a split hoof; it is unclean for you." - Leviticus 11:4

God told His people not to eat camels. Camels chew the cud. But they do not have a split hoof. They are unclean. God gave many rules about clean and unclean animals. Some animals could be eaten. Some could not. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about hooves?

The Big Surprise
"Do not call anything impure that God has made clean." - Acts 10:15

The rule about unclean animals was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. God used these rules to set His people apart. But Jesus came to make all things clean. He came to remove the barrier. He came to bring everyone in. The surprise is that Jesus makes the unclean clean.

Family Activity

Look at pictures of different animals. Talk about clean and unclean animals. Talk about how God used these rules to teach His people. Talk about how Jesus makes us clean. We do not have to worry about being clean enough. Jesus makes us clean.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for making me clean. Thank you for removing the barrier. Thank you for bringing me in. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A camel with a big smile.

Day 15: The Rule About the Sabbath

The Weird Rule
"For six days you may gather the manna, but on the seventh day, the Sabbath, there will not be any." - Exodus 16:26

God told His people not to gather manna on the Sabbath. The Sabbath was a day of rest. The people were not allowed to work. They could not gather food. They had to rest. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about resting?

The Big Surprise
"Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest." - Matthew 11:28

The rule about the Sabbath was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The Sabbath was a day of rest. It was a picture of the rest that Jesus gives. Jesus is our rest. He is the one who gives us peace. He is the one who gives us rest. The surprise is that Jesus is our rest. We can stop working. We can rest in Him.

Family Activity
Have a day of rest. Take a nap. Read a book. Go for a walk. Talk about how God wants us to rest. Talk about how Jesus is our rest. We can rest in Him.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being my rest. Thank you for giving me peace. Thank you for giving me rest. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A person sleeping peacefully with a big smile.

Day 16: The Rule About the Firstborn

The Weird Rule

"Consecrate to me every firstborn male. The first offspring of every womb among the Israelites belongs to me, whether human or animal." - Exodus 13:2

God told His people that every firstborn male belonged to Him. Every firstborn son. Every firstborn animal. They all belonged to God. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God want the firstborn?

The Big Surprise
"For those God foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, that he might be the firstborn among many brothers and sisters." - Romans 8:29

The rule about the firstborn was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the firstborn. He is the firstborn of all creation. He is the firstborn from the dead. He is the firstborn among many brothers and sisters. The surprise is that Jesus makes us part of the family. We are included.

Family Activity
Make a list of the firstborns in your family. Talk about how the firstborn belonged to God. Talk about how Jesus is the firstborn. Talk about how He makes us part of the family.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the firstborn. Thank you for making me part of the family. Thank you for including me. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A family with a big heart in the middle.

Day 17: The Rule About the Red Heifer

The Weird Rule
"Tell the Israelites to bring you a red heifer without defect or blemish and that has never been under a yoke." - Numbers 19:2

God told His people to bring a red heifer. It had to be perfect. It had to be red. It had to have no defects. It had to have never been under a yoke. This seems like a very strange rule. Why would God care about a red cow?

The Big Surprise
"And so Jesus also suffered outside the city gate to make the people holy through his own blood." - Hebrews 13:12

The rule about the red heifer was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The red heifer was taken outside the camp. It was burned. Its ashes were used to cleanse the people. Jesus was taken outside the city gate. He was crucified. His blood cleanses us. The surprise is that Jesus is the one who cleanses us.

Family Activity

Draw a picture of a red cow. Talk about how the red heifer was used to cleanse the people. Talk about how Jesus cleanses us. He makes us holy.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for cleansing me. Thank you for making me holy. Thank you for your blood. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A red cow with a big smile.

Day 18: The Rule About the Goat

The Weird Rule
"He is to lay both hands on the head of the live goat and confess over it all the wickedness and rebellion of the Israelites—all their sins—and put them on the goat's head." - Leviticus 16:21

God told His people about the scapegoat. The high priest would lay his hands on the goat. He would confess the sins of the people. He would put the sins on the goat's head. The goat would carry the sins away. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God put sins on a goat?

The Big Surprise
"We all, like sheep, have gone astray, each of us has turned to our own way; and the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all." - Isaiah 53:6

The rule about the goat was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the scapegoat. The sins of the world were laid on Him. He carried them away. He took them to the cross. He took them to the grave. The surprise is that Jesus is the one who carries our sins away.

Family Activity
Write a mistake on a piece of paper. Tie it to a balloon. Let the balloon go. Talk about how the goat carried the sins away. Talk about how Jesus carries our sins away. They are gone.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for carrying my sins away. Thank you for taking them to the cross. Thank you for removing them. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A goat with a big heart on it.

Day 19: The Rule About the High Priest's Clothes

The Weird Rule

"Make sacred garments for your brother Aaron to give him dignity and honor." - Exodus 28:2

God told His people to make special clothes for the high priest. They were to be beautiful. They were to be holy. They were to be set apart. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about clothes?

The Big Surprise
"For all of you who were baptized into Christ have clothed yourselves with Christ." - Galatians 3:27

The rule about the high priest's clothes was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is our High Priest. He is clothed in righteousness. He is clothed in holiness. He is clothed in glory. The surprise is that Jesus clothes us with Himself. We are covered. We are set apart. We are holy.

Family Activity
Dress up in fancy clothes. Put on a crown. Talk about how the high priest wore special clothes. Talk about how Jesus clothes us. We are covered by Him. We are set apart.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for clothing me. Thank you for covering me. Thank you for making me holy. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A robe with a big heart on it.

Day 20: The Rule About the Bell

The Weird Rule
"Make pomegranates of blue, purple and scarlet yarn around the hem of the robe, with gold bells between them." - Exodus 28:33

God told His people to put bells on the high priest's robe. Gold bells. Between pomegranates. The bells would jingle when he walked. The people would hear him. They would know he was alive. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about bells?

The Big Surprise
"For the Lord himself will come down from heaven, with a loud command, with the voice of the archangel and with the trumpet call of God, and the dead in Christ will rise first." - 1 Thessalonians 4:16

The rule about the bells was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The bells announced the high priest. Jesus is the one who is coming again. He will come with a loud command. He will come with a trumpet call. The surprise is that Jesus is the one we listen for. He is the one who is coming.

Family Activity
Tie some bells to your shoes. Walk around the room. Talk about how the bells on the high priest's robe jingled. Talk about how Jesus is coming again. We listen for His voice.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the one I listen for. Thank you for coming again. Help me to listen. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A bell with a big smile.

Day 21: The Rule About the Ark

The Weird Rule
"Have them make an ark of acacia wood—two and a half cubits long, a cubit and a half wide, and a cubit and a half high." - Exodus 25:10

God told His people to build an ark. It was a box. It was made of wood. It was covered in gold. It held the tablets of the law. It held the manna. It held Aaron's staff. It was the place where God met with His people. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God meet in a box?

The Big Surprise
"Jesus answered them, 'Destroy this temple, and I will raise it again in three days.' But the temple he had spoken of was his body." - John 2:19-21

The rule about the ark was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The ark was the meeting place. Jesus is the meeting place. He is the one who brings us to God. He is the one who makes a way. The surprise is that Jesus is the meeting place. We meet God in Him.

Family Activity
Make a small box. Decorate it with gold paper. Put something special inside. Talk about how the ark held the things of God. Talk about how Jesus is the meeting place. We meet God in Him.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the meeting place. Thank you for bringing me to God. Thank you for making a way. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A golden box with a big heart on it.

Day 22: The Rule About the Golden Lampstand

The Weird Rule
"Make a lampstand of pure gold. Hammer out its base and shaft, and make its flowerlike cups, buds and blossoms of one piece with them." - Exodus 25:31

God told His people to make a golden lampstand. It had seven branches. It had cups like flowers. It had buds and blossoms. It was beautiful. It was the only light in the tabernacle. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about a lampstand?

The Big Surprise
"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will never walk in darkness, but will have the light of life." - John 8:12

The rule about the lampstand was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the light of the world. He is the one who shines in the darkness. He is the one who guides us. The surprise is that Jesus is the light. We follow Him. We walk in His light.

Family Activity
Turn off the lights. Light a candle. Talk about how the lampstand was the only light in the tabernacle. Talk about how Jesus is the light of the world. He guides us. He shines in the darkness.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the light. Thank you for guiding me. Thank you for shining in the darkness. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A golden lampstand with a big smile.

Day 23: The Rule About the Table

The Weird Rule
"Make a table of acacia wood—two cubits long, a cubit wide and a cubit and a half high." - Exodus 25:23

God told His people to make a table. It was made of wood. It was covered in gold. It held the bread of the Presence. It was a special table. It was a holy table. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about a table?

The Big Surprise
"I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will never go hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty." - John 6:35

The rule about the table was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the bread of life. He is the one who feeds us. He is the one who satisfies us. The surprise is that Jesus is the bread. He is the one who fills us.

Family Activity
Set a special table. Put bread on it. Talk about how the table held the bread of the Presence. Talk about how Jesus is the bread of life. We can feed on Him. We can be satisfied.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the bread of life. Thank you for feeding me. Thank you for satisfying me. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A table with a loaf of bread and a big smile.

Day 24: The Rule About the Laver

The Weird Rule
"Make a bronze basin, with its bronze stand, for washing. Place it between the tent of meeting and the altar, and put water in it." - Exodus 30:18

God told His people to make a bronze basin. It was a laver. It held water. The priests washed their hands and feet before they entered the tabernacle. They had to be clean. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about washing?

The Big Surprise
"He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit." - Titus 3:5

The rule about the laver was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the one who washes us. He is the one who cleanses us. He is the one who renews us. The surprise is that Jesus washes us. We are clean because of Him.

Family Activity
Wash your hands together. Talk about how the priests washed before they entered the tabernacle. Talk about how Jesus washes us. He cleanses us. He renews us.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for washing me. Thank you for cleansing me. Thank you for renewing me. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A basin of water with a big smile.

Day 25: The Rule About the Incense

The Weird Rule
"Aaron must burn fragrant incense on the altar every morning when he tends the lamps." - Exodus 30:7

God told His people to burn incense. Every morning. On the altar. It was a sweet smell. It filled the tabernacle. It rose to heaven. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about incense?

The Big Surprise
"The smoke of the incense, together with the prayers of God's people, went up before God from the angel's hand." - Revelation 8:4

The rule about the incense was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The incense was a picture of prayer. It was a picture of worship. Jesus is the one who prays for us. He is the one who intercedes for us. The surprise is that Jesus is the one who prays for us. Our prayers rise to heaven because of Him.

Family Activity
Smell a sweet candle or flower. Talk about how the incense was a sweet smell. Talk about how our prayers rise to heaven. Jesus is the one who prays for us.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for praying for me. Thank you for interceding for me. Thank you for making my prayers rise to heaven. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A cloud of incense with a big heart.

Day 26: The Rule About the Veil

The Weird Rule
"Hang the curtain from the clasps and place the ark of the covenant law behind the curtain. The curtain will separate the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place." - Exodus 26:33

God told His people to make a veil. It was a thick curtain. It separated the people from the Most Holy Place. It separated them from the presence of God. The people could not go in. Only the high priest could go in. Once a year. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God separate Himself from His people?

The Big Surprise
"At that moment the curtain of the temple was torn in two from top to bottom." - Matthew 27:51

The rule about the veil was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The veil separated the people from God. When Jesus died, the veil was torn in two. The barrier was removed. The separation was ended. The surprise is that Jesus removed the barrier. We can come to God now. We have access.

Family Activity

Take a piece of paper. Talk about how it separates you from something. Then rip the paper in half. Talk about how the veil was torn when Jesus died. We can come to God now. We have access.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for removing the barrier. Thank you for tearing the veil. Thank you for giving me access to God. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A torn curtain with a big heart.

Day 27: The Rule About the Altar

The Weird Rule
"Build an altar of acacia wood, three cubits high; it is to be square, five cubits long and five cubits wide." - Exodus 27:1

God told His people to build an altar. It was made of wood. It was covered in bronze. It was the place of sacrifice. It was the place of fire. It was the place where the blood was shed. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God need an altar?

The Big Surprise
"We have an altar from which those who minister at the tabernacle have no right to eat." - Hebrews 13:10

The rule about the altar was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the altar. He is the sacrifice. He is the place where sin is dealt with. He is the place where blood is shed. The surprise is that Jesus is the altar. He is the one who took the fire for us.

Family Activity
Build an altar out of blocks. Put a toy animal on it. Talk about how the altar was the place of sacrifice. Talk about how Jesus is the altar. He took the fire for us. He is the sacrifice.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the altar. Thank you for taking the fire for me. Thank you for being the sacrifice. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
An altar with a big heart on it.

Day 28: The Rule About the Two Cherubim

The Weird Rule
"And make two cherubim out of hammered gold at the ends of the cover." - Exodus 25:18

God told His people to make two cherubim. They were angels. They were made of gold. They were placed on the mercy seat. They faced each other. Their wings spread out. They represented the presence of God. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God care about angels?

The Big Surprise
"And he made known to us the mystery of his will according to his good pleasure, which he purposed in Christ, to be put into effect when the times reach their fulfillment—to bring unity to all things in heaven and on earth under Christ." - Ephesians 1:9-10

The rule about the two cherubim was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. The cherubim represented unity. They represented the presence of God. Jesus is the one who brings unity. He is the one who brings heaven and earth together. The surprise is that Jesus is the one who brings unity. He brings us together.

Family Activity
Draw two angels facing each other. Talk about how the cherubim were on the mercy seat. Talk about how Jesus brings unity. He brings heaven and earth together. He brings us together.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for bringing unity. Thank you for bringing heaven and earth together. Thank you for bringing us together. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
Two angels with a big heart between them.

Day 29: The Rule About the Mercy Seat

The Weird Rule
"Make an atonement cover of pure gold—two and a half cubits long and a cubit and a half wide." - Exodus 25:17

God told His people to make a mercy seat. It was the lid of the ark. It was made of pure gold. It was the place where the blood was sprinkled. It was the place of atonement. It was the place of mercy. This seems like a strange rule. Why would God need a mercy seat?

The Big Surprise
"God presented Christ as a sacrifice of atonement, through the shedding of his blood—to be received by faith." - Romans 3:25

The rule about the mercy seat was a shadow. It pointed to Jesus. Jesus is the mercy seat. He is the atonement. He is the place of mercy. His blood was sprinkled. His sacrifice was made. The surprise is that Jesus is the mercy seat. He is the place where justice and mercy meet.

Family Activity
Draw a golden box with a lid. Talk about how the mercy seat was the lid of the ark. Talk about how Jesus is the mercy seat. He is the place of mercy. We can come to Him.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the mercy seat. Thank you for being the atonement. Thank you for being the place of mercy. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A golden box with a big smile on the lid.

Day 30: The Real Surprise

The Weird Rule
"These are a shadow of the things that were to come; the reality, however, is found in Christ." - Colossians 2:17

All the weird rules were shadows. They were clues. They were pointing to something. They were pointing to someone. They were pointing to Jesus.

The Big Surprise
"For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed." - 1 Corinthians 5:7

Jesus is the real surprise. He is the fulfillment of every weird rule. He is the meaning behind every strange ceremony. He is the treasure at the end of the hunt. The surprise is that Jesus is the one we were looking for all along.

Family Activity
Have a surprise party. Make a cake. Light a candle. Talk about how all the weird rules were pointing to Jesus. Talk about how Jesus is the real surprise. We found Him. We love Him. We thank Him.

Kid's Prayer
"Thank you, Jesus, for being the real surprise. Thank you for being the fulfillment of every weird rule. Thank you for being the treasure. Help me to live in the reality. Help me to live in you. I love you. Amen."

Coloring Prompt
A big treasure chest with a cross and a big smile.

END MATTER

The "Prophecy Detective" Certificate

This certifies that [Child's Name] has completed the Shadows and Surprises adventure. You followed 30 secret clues and discovered the greatest treasure: Jesus. You are officially a Divine Blueprint Detective.

Date: _____

Signed by (Parent or Teacher): _____

Family Discussion Cards

Card 1: What was the weirdest rule you learned about?
Card 2: Why do you think God gave so many strange rules?
Card 3: What is your favorite surprise from this book?
Card 4: How does it feel to know Jesus is the real treasure?
Card 5: Who is someone you can tell about Jesus?
Card 6: What is your favorite prayer from this book?
Card 7: If you could ask Jesus one question, what would it be?
Card 8: What is one way you can show Jesus' love to someone today?
Card 9: What is your favorite coloring page from this book?
Card 10: What is one thing you want to remember about Jesus forever?

A Note for the Parent: Building on the Foundation

You did it. You spent 30 days discovering the surprise behind the weird rules. But the adventure does not end here. It is just beginning.

Here are a few tips to keep going:

1. Make it a habit, not a chore. Do not stress about reading the Bible for 30 minutes a day. A simple 5 minute rhythm before bed is better than an hour once a month.
2. Let them see you reading. Kids do what they see. Let them catch you reading your Bible. Let them see that it matters to you.
3. Ask "Where is Jesus?" in every story. Whenever you read a Bible story, ask your child, "Where do you see Jesus in this story?" This trains them to look for Jesus everywhere.
4. Recommended next steps. Read The Jesus Storybook Bible by Sally Lloyd-Jones. Read The Biggest Story by Kevin DeYoung. Keep pointing them to the Treasure.

You are doing a great job. Keep going.

Sneak Peek: The Greatest Festival Ever

If you loved this adventure, there is another one waiting for you. The Greatest Festival Ever takes you on a journey through the Old Testament parties that point to Jesus. It is full of fun activities, coloring pages, and simple prayers.

Final Call to Action

Scan the QR code below to get the next book in the series. Visit our website to download a free reading plan. Join our community of families. The adventure is not over. The journey is just beginning.

Cover Design Concept (The Children's Edition)

A bright yellow or sky blue background. A cartoon child detective with a magnifying glass. The child is looking at a big, colorful present with a question mark on it. A small, friendly cartoon lamb is sitting next to the child. The title SHADOWS AND SURPRISES is in a chunky, bouncy, playful font. The word SURPRISES is in bright red with a question mark replacing the letter S. The overall feel is fun, exciting, and irresistible to a child.